CELERIAC SCHNITZEL WITH SALSA VERDE

by Danielle Alvarez, featured in Always Add Lemon
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INTRODUCTION

Anytime I can produce a recipe that swaps out meat for a vegetable but gives equal satisfaction, I feel I have achieved something. Although I am not a vegetarian, I don't want to eat meat every day, and with such abundance of fresh fruits and vegetables where I live, I like to take advantage of it. Also, it just makes you feel good to eat a lot of vegetables. Even if they are crumbed and fried in clarified butter. This could be served with so many things, but I would probably opt for a nice radicchio or rocket (arugula) salad.

Photo by Benito Martin and Jess Johnson

INGREDIENTS

Serves: 4

CELERIAC SCHNITZEL

- 1 large celeriac (peeled)
- 30 grams butter
- 4 thyme sprigs
- 50 grams plain flour
- 2 eggs (beaten)
- 100 grams panko breadcrumbs
- 200 millilitres ghee (clarified butter) for frying

TO SERVE

- salsa verde with capers (see below)
- lemons wedges
- salad greens

SALSA VERDE

- 2 tablespoons finely chopped shallots (approx. 1 small shallot)
- 3 tablespoons red wine vinegar or lemon juice
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1 bunch chervil (5–10 g/ ⅛–¼ oz leaves)
- 1 bunch flatleaf parsley (approx. 30 g/1 oz leaves)
- 100 millilitres extra virgin olive oil
- 3 anchovy fillets (finely chopped)
- 2½ tablespoons salt-packed capers (rinsed then chopped)

METHOD

Celeriac Schnitzel with Salsa Verde is a guest recipe by Danielle Alvarez so we are not able to answer questions regarding this recipe

FOR THE CELERIAC SCHNITZEL

1. Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F).
2. Cut the celeriac into 1.5 cm (½ in) thick slices. You should get four nice slices from one large celeriac, but if yours is a bit smaller, just use two and serve two slices per portion.
3. Place the celeriac in a baking dish and season with salt and pepper. Add the butter, thyme and 100 ml (3½ fl oz) water and cover with aluminium foil.
4. Bake for 30 minutes, or until a knife can be inserted with ease. Remove from the dish and allow to cool.
5. Set up a crumbing station. Add the flour to one dish, the egg to another, and the breadcrumbs to a third. Since you are only crumbing one side, you want to make sure that the dish with the eggs in it is shallow so that the egg just barely goes up the sides of the celeriac.
6. Dredge the slices first in the flour, then the egg, making sure the egg really sticks, and then, finally, in the breadcrumbs. Set aside.
7. Heat a wide sauté or cast-iron pan over a medium heat and allow it to get hot before adding the clarified butter. You want enough butter to go up the side of the celeriac, but not submerge it, so you may need to add more or less depending on the size of your pan. You can also cook these in batches if you only have a small pan.
8. When the butter is good and hot, place a slice of celeriac, crumbed side down, in the pan and cook until it is golden brown. You want this to happen over the course of 4 or

so minutes. If it happens too quickly, your pan is too hot and you won't get that crisp exterior. Once brown, flip the celeriac over and cook for a minute or so just to make sure it's warmed through.

9. Season liberally with salt and pepper as soon as it comes out of the butter.
10. Once fried, serve on a warm plate or platter with salsa verde and lemon wedges.

FOR THE SALSA VERDE

1. This recipe starts the same way as a vinaigrette: soak the shallots in the vinegar and salt. Set aside.
2. Wash and pick the leaves from the parsley and chervil and dry completely. Don't be too fussy about the stems, thin and fine stems are perfectly fine to go in the salsa.
3. Chop quite finely – you need a sharp knife for this; a dull knife will bruise the herbs and muddy their bright, verdant flavour. I also am opposed to making salsa verde in a blender; hand-chopped produces the cleanest flavour and the extra effort is worth it.
4. Add the olive oil, anchovies and capers to the herbs, then add the shallot vinegar. Mix well and set aside for at least 1 hour. This allows the flavours to meld and become cohesive.
5. This sauce can be saved for the following day, but it will discolour due to the acid being in contact with the herbs, so it's best served the day it is made.